birthday, because I couldn't help comparing it with my twenty-sixth, which was spent in the Army. On the other hand, I was more than half as old as my father. I was suddenly aware that I was older by nearly four years than my father had been when I was born.

I was becoming distinctly mature.

I bought myself a postbirthday present—a slide rule. I had ordered one from the bookstore a long time before, but there was a postwar backlog of orders to fill and it wasn't till January 10 that mine came through. It was, according to my diary, "A Dietsgen decitrig duplex polyphase log-log slide rule" and it cost me $16. I still own it and it works as well as ever.

A hundred-page booklet of instructions came with it, and I read just enough of it to get the idea and then fiddled with the slide rule itself and learned how to work it. It was much more fun doing it for myself.

If Razran had only showed me how to multiply two by three on the slide rule back in 1936, I would have gained a decade.

My first use of the slide rule was to check some of the figures in Gertrude's bookkeeping in connection with the Henry Paper Box Company. It was an exciting procedure, marred only by the fact that every time my reading disagreed with her figures, it was my reading that was wrong.

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Another connection with Army life was broken. Jerome Himel-hoch, who had been part of Kriegman's group along with me in my last weeks in the Army, was himself out of the Army now. We visited him and his family on January 31. On the way there, I took Gertrude to my

Columbia research laboratory for the first time and proudly showed her the fancy equipment I was using.

2 3

I finally finished "Now You See It—" on February 2. It was twenty-five thousand words long, only half as long as "The Mule/' but it still took me several months to complete.

Partly this was because I was still collecting my notes for the book on World War II I wanted to write. Looking back on it now, I grow impatient with